Practical AI for Professionals

Frameworks Reference Sheet

Executive Education Curtin Business School

Your quick-reference guide to the trust tool and the four practical frameworks

The Spine and the Four Frameworks

This reference sheet provides quick access to the trust tool and the four frameworks taught in the Practical AI for Professionals Masterclass.

What You'll Find:

The Trust Tool (the spine) - One grid: Average/Precise × Small/Large - Decide how much to trust any AI output, on any tool

Framework 1: AI Task Suitability Spectrum - Decide when AI can help and when it can't - Four zones from AI-Led to Human-Only

Framework 2: RTCF Prompt Framework - Structure effective briefs for any AI tool, conversation, not delegation - Four components: Role, Task, Context, Format

Framework 3: AI-Assisted Analysis Workflow - Use AI systematically for data analysis - Six steps from Prepare to Present

Framework 4: AI Opportunity Finder - Spot AI opportunities in your daily work - Four categories: Automate, Assist, Generate, Analyse

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How to Use This Guide

During the workshop: - Keep this on your desk for quick reference - Use it during exercises to apply frameworks - Annotate with your own insights and notes

After the workshop: - Pin near your workspace - Reference before starting any AI-assisted task - Share with colleagues who want to start using AI

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The Trust Tool: The Spine of the Day

Purpose: Decide how much to trust any AI output, before you act on it

The question it answers: "*Can I trust this, and how much checking does it need?*"

The Key Insight

AI produces a **convincing average**: fluent, well-shaped, usually about right. But "about right" and "exactly right" are not the same thing, and knowing which one you need is the whole game. The tool carries the form of good work; you supply the substance it can't: the context, the judgement, and the check.

Two Questions

Q1, Do you need an average, or precision? - **Average** = "in the ballpark" is fine: a first draft, a summary, a starting point you'll shape - **Precise** = one correct value, where close is the same as wrong: figures, citations, names, numbers

Q2, Are the stakes small or large? - **Small** = easy to reverse, cheap to get wrong, no one harmed - **Large** = real consequences: money, safety, reputation, someone's job

The Four Corners

	Small (low stakes)	**Large (high stakes)**
Average is fine	**Lean in.** Let AI run.	**Lean in, with a glance.** Sanity-check before it goes out.
Precision required	**Use, then verify.** Confirm the specifics.	**Human in the loop.** A person owns the decision.

Remember

- **Lean in** where "about right" over low stakes is fine
- **Keep a human in the loop** where exactly-right meets high stakes
- **Verification comes from outside the tool.** Asking the AI to check its own work doesn't count, check against the data, the source, or an independent standard
- Fluency is not evidence. The smoother the output, the more reason to check the load-bearing parts

From Conversation, Not Delegation *(michael-borck.github.io/conversation-not-delegation)*

Framework 1: AI Task Suitability Spectrum

Purpose: Decide whether a task is suitable for AI assistance, and what kind of assistance

The question it answers: "*Should I use AI for this, and how much should I rely on it?*"

The Four Zones

Zone	AI Role	Your Role	Best For
AI-Led	Does the heavy lifting	Review and approve	Routine, pattern-based work
AI-Assisted	Provides substantial help	Guide and verify	Tasks needing judgment + speed
Human-Led, AI-Supported	Handles sub-tasks	Lead the overall work	Complex work with routine parts
Human-Only	Not involved	Full ownership	Empathy, ethics, novel judgment

Zone 1: AI-Led

AI does most of the work. You review, approve, and send.

Characteristics of these tasks: - Routine and repetitive - Clear patterns and formats - Low risk if output is imperfect - High volume

Examples: - Formatting raw notes into meeting minutes - Converting bullet points into a polished email - Translating a document between languages - Generating a first draft of a standard report - Summarising a long article to key points

Your role: Provide clear instructions, review output for errors, make final edits.

Zone 2: AI-Assisted

AI provides substantial help, but you're actively shaping the work throughout.

Characteristics of these tasks: - Require some professional judgment - Benefit from speed or breadth AI provides - Medium risk, errors would be noticed - Iterative process (multiple rounds of refinement)

Examples: - Drafting a client proposal (AI drafts, you refine with client knowledge) - Analysing survey results (AI finds patterns, you interpret meaning) - Researching a topic (AI gathers information, you evaluate relevance) - Writing a job description (AI drafts structure, you add role-specific nuance) - Preparing presentation slides (AI generates outline and content, you adjust for audience)

Your role: Set direction, review critically, add expertise the AI can't have, iterate.

Zone 3: Human-Led, AI-Supported

You lead the work. AI handles specific sub-tasks within it.

Characteristics of these tasks: - Complex overall, but contain routine components - Require strategic thinking or creative direction - High stakes, quality matters significantly - AI can accelerate specific parts

Examples: - Strategy document (you set direction; AI helps with research, formatting, competitor data) - Performance review (you assess the person; AI helps structure the feedback document) - Project planning (you make decisions; AI helps generate risk lists, timeline drafts, checklists) - Negotiation preparation (you plan the approach; AI helps summarise past interactions, draft talking points) - Budget proposal (you set priorities; AI helps model scenarios, format tables)

Your role: Own the thinking and decisions. Delegate well-defined sub-tasks to AI.

Zone 4: Human-Only

AI should not be involved. These tasks require qualities AI does not have.

Characteristics of these tasks: - Require genuine empathy or emotional intelligence - Involve ethical judgment with real consequences - Need deep personal or organisational context - Demand accountability that can't be delegated

Examples: - Having a difficult conversation with an employee - Making a decision that affects someone's career - Navigating a sensitive political situation - Responding to a personal crisis in your team - Setting the creative vision for a project - Making ethical trade-offs with no clear right answer

Your role: Full ownership. Your judgment, your empathy, your accountability.

Quick Decision Guide

Ask yourself these questions about any task:

```
1. Is this routine and pattern-based?
   YES → Consider AI-Led
   NO  → Continue...

2. Does it need my professional judgment throughout?
   YES → Consider AI-Assisted
   NO  → Continue...

3. Is it complex overall, but has routine sub-parts?
   YES → Consider Human-Led, AI-Supported
   NO  → Continue...

4. Does it require empathy, ethics, or accountability?
   YES → Human-Only
```

When in doubt, start with more human involvement and delegate to AI as you build trust.

Framework 2: RTCF Prompt Framework

Purpose: Brief AI effectively so it gets useful output on the first or second try

The question it answers: "*How do I ask AI for what I actually need?*"

The mindset, conversation, not delegation: prompting is not an incantation. It's briefing a capable junior colleague who knows nothing about your job. Everything you'd tell a smart new hire before they drafted this for you belongs in the prompt. The tool returns the form of the work; you supply the substance, the intent, the background, the standard it will be judged against.

The Four Components

Every effective prompt contains some combination of these four elements:

R, Role

Tell the AI who it should be.

Why it matters: Setting a role activates relevant patterns in the AI's training. A "financial analyst" writes differently than a "marketing copywriter."

Examples: - "You are an experienced project manager..." - "Act as a data analyst who specialises in retail..." - "You are a professional editor reviewing a business document..." - "Respond as a customer service trainer..."

Tip: Be specific. "You are a senior HR consultant with 15 years of experience in Australian employment law" is far more useful than "You are an HR expert."

T, Task

Tell the AI exactly what to do.

Why it matters: Vague tasks produce vague results. Specific tasks produce specific results.

Bad: - "Help me with this report" - "Write something about our project" - "Analyse this data"

Good: - "Summarise this report into 5 bullet points for a board presentation" - "Write a 200-word project status update covering progress, risks, and next steps" - "Identify the top 3 trends in this dataset and explain why each matters"

Tip: Include the verb (summarise, draft, analyse, compare, explain, list, rewrite) and the scope (how many, how long, what to cover).

C, Context

Give the AI the background it needs.

Why it matters: AI doesn't know your company, your audience, your history, or your constraints. Without context, it gives generic output. Context is the *grounding* only you can supply, it's the part of the work the tool genuinely cannot do for you.

Types of context to provide: - **Audience:** "This is for senior executives who are not technical" - **Stakes:** "Write this for someone who has to decide this week and can't undo it", real stakes sharpen the rigour of the output - **Background:** "We're a mid-sized retail company with 500 employees" - **Constraints:** "Keep it under 300 words" or "Use Australian English" - **Situation:** "We just lost a major client and need to reassure the team" - **Prior work:** Paste in relevant documents, notes, or data

Tip: More context almost always produces better results. When in doubt, include it.

F, Format

Tell the AI how to structure the output.

Why it matters: Without format instructions, AI defaults to generic paragraphs. Specifying format gives you output you can actually use.

Format options: - "Use bullet points" - "Present as a numbered list" - "Create a table with columns for [X], [Y], [Z]" - "Write in short paragraphs, no more than 3 sentences each" - "Use headers and sub-headers" - "Format as an email with subject line" - "Structure as: Problem, Analysis, Recommendation"

Tip: If you want output you can paste directly into a document, specify the exact format of that document.

Putting It All Together

Basic prompt (no framework): > "Write me an email about the project delay"

RTCF prompt: > **Role:** You are a project manager who communicates clearly and professionally. > > **Task:** Write an email to the client explaining that our project delivery will be delayed by 2 weeks. > > **Context:** The delay is due to a vendor dependency, their API integration took longer than expected. The client is generally understanding but values transparency. We have a good relationship. The new delivery date is March 15. > > **Format:** Keep the email under 200 words. Use a professional but warm tone. Structure as: acknowledge the delay, explain the reason briefly, confirm the new date, reaffirm our commitment.

The difference: The first prompt produces a generic email you'll need to heavily rewrite. The second produces something close to what you'd actually send.

RTCF Quick Reference Card

Component	Question to Ask Yourself	Example
Role	Who should the AI be?	"You are a senior financial analyst"
Task	What exactly should it do?	"Create a variance analysis comparing Q1 to Q2"
Context	What does the AI need to know?	"This is for a CFO who wants a 2-minute verbal summary"
Format	How should the output look?	"Table with 3 columns: Category, Variance, Explanation"

Not every prompt needs all four. A simple task might only need T and F. A complex task benefits from all four. Use your judgment.

Common Prompt Mistakes

Mistake 1: Too vague - "Help me with this" → AI has nothing to work with - Fix: Add a specific task verb and scope

Mistake 2: No context - "Write a marketing email" → Generic, unusable output - Fix: Add audience, product, tone, purpose

Mistake 3: No format specification - "Analyse this data" → Wall of text you can't use - Fix: Specify bullet points, tables, word counts, structure

Mistake 4: Too much at once - "Write a full business case with executive summary, market analysis, financial projections, risk assessment, and implementation plan" → Shallow on everything - Fix: Break into separate prompts, one section at a time

Mistake 5: Not iterating - Accepting the first output as final - Fix: Treat the first response as a draft. Say "Make it more concise" or "Add more detail on X" or "Change the tone to be more formal"

Framework 3: AI-Assisted Analysis Workflow

Purpose: A systematic process for using AI to analyse data and produce trustworthy insights

The question it answers: "*How do I use AI to make sense of my data without getting fooled by wrong answers?*"

The Six Steps

```
PREPARE  →  UPLOAD  →  QUESTION  →  VERIFY  →  REFINE  →  PRESENT
   1          2          3          4          5          6
```

Step 1: Prepare

Before you touch any AI tool, clarify what you want to know.

Do This	Not This
"What are the top drivers of customer complaints in Q4?"	"Analyse this spreadsheet"
"Is there a relationship between team size and project delays?"	"Look at this data and tell me something interesting"
"Which product categories are growing fastest month-over-month?"	"What does this data mean?"

Why it matters: If you don't know what question you're answering, you can't evaluate whether the AI's answer is good.

Start a fresh chat. Long conversations drift: after many exchanges, the model absorbs your framing and slowly stops challenging you. A new chat gives you an independent read on your question.

Checklist: - [ ] What is the specific question I need answered? - [ ] Am I starting a fresh chat (not continuing an old conversation)? - [ ] Who is the audience for the findings? - [ ] What decisions will this analysis inform? - [ ] What would a useful answer look like?

Step 2: Upload

Get your data into the AI tool.

Methods: - **Copy/paste:** Works for small datasets (<100 rows). Paste directly into the chat. - **File upload:** Most AI tools accept CSV, Excel, and PDF files. Use this for larger datasets. - **Describe it:** If you can't share the data, describe its structure. "I have a spreadsheet with 500 rows. Columns are: Date, Product, Region, Sales, Returns."

Before uploading, check: - [ ] Does this data contain personal or confidential information? (If yes, do NOT upload to free-tier AI tools) - [ ] Is the data clean enough? (Remove obvious errors, fill blank headers) - [ ] Are column names clear? (Rename cryptic headers before uploading)

Tip: Clean column names and consistent formatting make a bigger difference than you'd expect. "Q4_Revenue_AUD" is much better than "col_7".

Step 3: Question

Ask progressively deeper questions.

Start broad, then narrow down:

Round	Type	Example
1	**Overview**	

Round	Type	Example
		"Summarise this dataset. What are the key columns, how many rows, and what time period does it cover?"
2	**Descriptive**	"What are the averages, minimums, and maximums for the Sales column? Break down by Region."
3	**Patterns**	"Are there any trends over time? Which months show unusual spikes or drops?"
4	**Drivers**	"What factors seem most associated with high return rates?"
5	**Recommendations**	"Based on this analysis, what are the top 3 actions you'd recommend to reduce returns?"

Tip: Each question builds on the previous answer. If something in the AI's response surprises you, follow up: "You mentioned Region C has the highest returns, break that down by product category."

Step 4: Verify

Cross-check the AI's findings against what you know.

Verification checklist: - [ ] Do the numbers match what I'd expect? (Spot-check totals, averages) - [ ] Does this align with what I already know about the business? - [ ] Are there obvious errors? (e.g., percentages that don't add to 100, impossible values) - [ ] Did the AI interpret my question correctly? - [ ] If it created a chart, do the axes and labels make sense?

Common AI analysis errors: - Miscounting rows (especially with filtered data) - Confusing correlation with causation - Ignoring missing data instead of flagging it - Producing mathematically impossible results (e.g., growth rates that don't match the underlying numbers) - Inventing data points that aren't in the source

The rule: If a finding would change a decision, verify it manually before acting on it.

Step 5: Refine

Iterate based on what you've learned.

Common refinement prompts: - "Break this down further by [category]" - "Exclude [outliers/time period] and re-run the analysis" - "Focus only on [specific segment], what patterns emerge?" - "The return rate you calculated seems high, double-check your methodology" - "Create a chart showing [specific comparison]"

Tip: The best analyses come from 3-5 rounds of questioning and refinement, not from a single prompt.

Step 6: Present

Have AI help format findings for your audience.

Prompt template for presentation-ready output:

Based on our analysis, create a summary for [audience]. Include: - Key finding 1 with supporting data - Key finding 2 with supporting data - Key finding 3 with supporting data - Recommended actions

Format as [bullet points / one-page brief / executive summary / presentation slides]. Use [plain language / technical detail] appropriate for [audience].

Remember: The AI's analysis is your starting point. Add your professional interpretation, business context, and judgment before presenting.

Workflow Quick Reference

Step	Action	Time
1. Prepare	Define the question	5 min
2. Upload	Get data into the tool	2 min
3. Question	Ask progressively deeper questions	10-15 min
4. Verify	Cross-check findings	5-10 min
5. Refine	Iterate and go deeper	5-10 min
6. Present	Format for your audience	5 min

Total: 30-45 minutes for a solid AI-assisted analysis (vs. hours doing it manually)

Framework 4: AI Opportunity Finder

Purpose: Identify where AI can add value in your daily work

The question it answers: "*Which parts of my job should I start using AI for?*"

The Four Opportunity Types

1. Automate, High-Volume, Repetitive Tasks

The signal: You do it frequently, it follows the same pattern, and it doesn't require judgment.

Examples: | Task | AI Automation | |------|--------------| | Formatting weekly reports | AI generates from raw data in consistent format | | Sorting and categorising emails | AI labels and routes based on content | | Scheduling follow-ups | AI suggests times and drafts reminders | | Data entry from forms | AI extracts and enters structured data | | Status update compilation | AI aggregates updates from multiple sources |

Where to start: Pick the task you do most frequently that bores you the most. That's your first automation candidate.

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2. Assist, Information Synthesis and Research

The signal: You spend time reading, gathering, comparing, or summarising information from multiple sources.

Examples: | Task | AI Assistance | |------|--------------| | Researching a topic before a meeting | AI summarises key articles and perspectives | | Reviewing long documents | AI extracts key points and flags important sections | | Comparing vendor proposals | AI creates side-by-side comparison tables | | Preparing meeting briefings | AI synthesises relevant background from multiple sources | | Staying current on industry trends | AI summarises recent developments |

Where to start: Pick the research or reading task that takes you the longest. Try giving AI the source material and asking for a summary.

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3. Generate, Content Drafting and Creation

The signal: You create written content regularly, emails, reports, proposals, presentations, documentation.

Examples: | Task | AI Generation | |------|--------------| | Client emails | AI drafts based on context, you edit and send | | Meeting agendas | AI generates from objectives and attendee list | | Process documentation | AI drafts from your verbal explanation | | Presentation outlines | AI creates structure from your key points | | Job postings | AI drafts from role requirements |

Where to start: Pick the document you write most often. Give AI a good example of one you've written before and ask it to draft the next one.

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4. Analyse, Data Review and Pattern Detection

The signal: You work with data, spreadsheets, or reports and need to find meaning in them.

Examples: | Task | AI Analysis | |------|------------| | Monthly performance reviews | AI identifies trends and anomalies in KPI data | | Customer feedback analysis | AI categorises themes and sentiment | | Budget variance analysis | AI highlights significant deviations and possible causes | | Survey results interpretation | AI groups responses and identifies patterns | | Competitive benchmarking | AI compares metrics across competitors |

Where to start: Pick a dataset or report you review regularly. Upload it to an AI tool and ask "What are the 3 most important things I should know from this data?"

Finding Your Opportunities: The Weekly Audit

Spend 10 minutes mapping your typical week:

Step 1: List your recurring tasks

Write down everything you do in a typical week that takes more than 15 minutes.

Step 2: Categorise each task

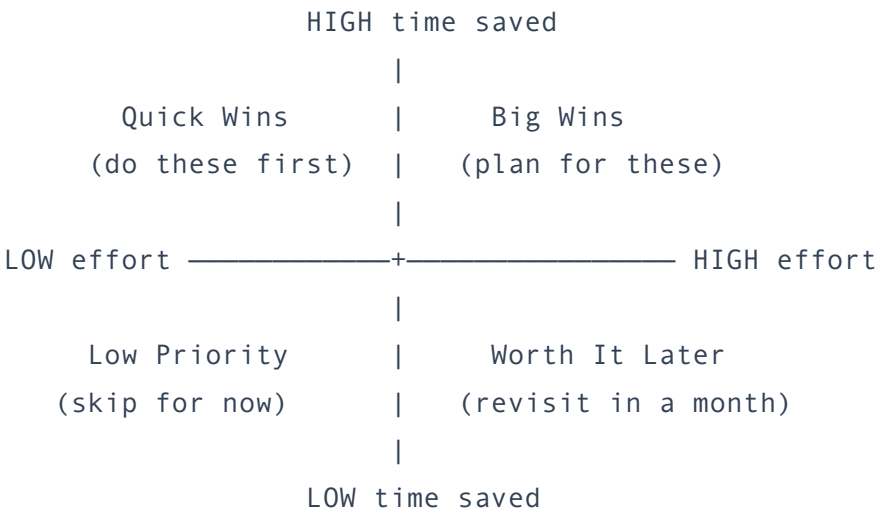
Task	Category	Current Time	AI Potential
Example: Write weekly status report	Generate	45 min	High, AI can draft from my notes
Example: Review team expense claims	Analyse	30 min	Medium, AI can flag outliers
Example: Coach underperforming team member	Human-Only	60 min	None, requires empathy

Step 3: Pick your first three

Choose the three tasks with the highest AI potential and the most time saved. Start with those.

The Priority Matrix

Use this to decide what to tackle first:



Quick Wins (low effort, high time saved): Start here. These build confidence and momentum. **Big Wins (high effort, high time saved):** Plan for these. They often require workflow redesign. **Worth It Later:** Revisit after you've built AI fluency from the quick wins. **Low Priority:** Don't bother unless something changes.

How the Four Frameworks Work Together

The frameworks build on each other in a natural sequence:

```
Step 1: SHOULD I use AI for this?
        → AI Task Suitability Spectrum

Step 2: HOW do I ask AI effectively?
        → RTCF Prompt Framework

Step 3: How do I use AI with DATA specifically?
        → AI-Assisted Analysis Workflow

Step 4: WHERE else in my work can AI help?
        → AI Opportunity Finder
```

In practice:

1. **Encounter a task** at work
2. **Check the Spectrum**: is this AI-Led, AI-Assisted, Human-Led, or Human-Only?
3. **If AI is involved**, write a prompt using **RTCF**
4. **If the task involves data**, follow the **Analysis Workflow**
5. **Once a week**, use the **Opportunity Finder** to spot new tasks to try with AI

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake 1: Starting with the hardest task - What happens: You pick your most complex task, get disappointing results, and give up - Fix: Start with a Quick Win. Build skills on easy tasks before tackling complex ones

Mistake 2: Using AI without verifying - What happens: You send AI-generated content with errors, damaging your credibility - Fix: Always review. The 2 minutes you spend checking saves the hours spent fixing mistakes

Mistake 3: Vague prompts, then blaming the tool - What happens: "Write me a report" produces generic output, so you conclude AI is useless - Fix: Use RTCF. Invest 60 seconds in a good prompt, save 60 minutes in revision

Mistake 4: Trying to automate Human-Only tasks - What happens: Using AI for tasks requiring empathy or ethical judgment produces tone-deaf results - Fix: Check the Suitability Spectrum first. Some tasks are yours alone

Mistake 5: Not iterating - What happens: Accepting the first output as final, even when it's not quite right - Fix: Treat AI output as a first draft. Follow up: "Make it shorter," "Add more detail on X," "Change the tone"

Mistake 6: Forgetting about privacy - What happens: Pasting confidential data into a free AI tool - Fix: Check your company's AI policy. When in doubt, don't upload sensitive data

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Your Action Plan

This week: 1. Pick ONE task from the Opportunity Finder and try it with AI 2. Use the RTCF framework for every prompt you write 3. Compare AI-assisted output to what you would have done manually

This month: 1. Build a personal prompt library for your 5 most common tasks 2. Try the Analysis Workflow on a real dataset from your work 3. Audit your full weekly schedule using the Opportunity Finder
This quarter: 1. Identify 3 workflows in your role that benefit from AI integration 2. Share what you've learned with your team 3. Explore the next course in the series: *AI-Driven Business Innovation*

Quick Reference Summary

When to Use Each Framework:

AI Task Suitability Spectrum - **Use when:** You're about to start a task and wondering if AI can help - **Question it answers:** "Should I use AI for this, and how much?" - **Output:** Zone classification (AI-Led / AI-Assisted / Human-Led / Human-Only)

RTCF Prompt Framework - **Use when:** You're about to type a prompt into any AI tool - **Question it answers:** "How do I ask for what I actually need?" - **Output:** A structured prompt that gets better results

AI-Assisted Analysis Workflow - **Use when:** You need to make sense of data using AI - **Question it answers:** "How do I get trustworthy insights from AI analysis?" - **Output:** Verified findings ready to present

AI Opportunity Finder - **Use when:** You want to find more ways to use AI in your role - **Question it answers:** "Where else can AI help me?" - **Output:** Prioritised list of tasks to try with AI

The One-Line Version

Tool	Remember This
Trust Tool	Average or precise? Small or large stakes? That tells you how much to check
Suitability Spectrum	Not every task needs AI, know the zones
RTCF	Role, Task, Context, Format, brief it like a colleague
Analysis Workflow	Prepare the question before you touch the tool
Opportunity Finder	Start with quick wins, build from there

Key Principles Across All Frameworks

- **Conversation, not delegation**: brief AI like a capable junior colleague; the substance comes from you
- **Your judgement is the edge**: everyone has the same tools; what you add is what differentiates
- **Verify from outside**: the tool can't reliably check its own work; especially facts, numbers, and reasoning
- **Start small, build confidence**: quick wins before big workflows
- **Iterate, don't accept**: first drafts are starting points

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Agents, Harnesses, and Skills: A Field Guide

The next step past chat is the **agent**: AI that plans and acts in a loop with tools (search, files, other software) until a job is done. What shapes that loop is the **harness**: the software around the model, its standing instructions, the context it can read, the tools it may call, and the model it runs on.

The part you own is the **skill**: a plain-text brief in a folder that the harness loads when your request matches it. Your RTCF structure, your output format, and your verification rules are exactly what belongs in one. Because a skill is just text, it moves with you between tools.

And the trust tool still applies: **an agent automates the loop, not the standard.** A loop that checks its own work inherits the model's blind spots. Whatever an agent produces still needs your check, from outside.

What Your Assistant Remembers About You

Assistants increasingly learn across sessions. That knowledge lives in **three separate stores**, managed separately:

Store	What It Is	How to Manage It
What you told it	Explicit facts you asked it to save ("remember that I prefer...")	Review and delete in memory/personalisation settings
What it inferred	Patterns drawn from your chats, why an assistant can start to feel "too personal"	Separate toggle; deleting chats does **not** delete this
The chats themselves	The conversation history you can see	Delete individually or in bulk via your account's privacy/data settings

Practices: - **Review periodically**: look for "memory", "personalisation", or "data controls" in settings (names vary by platform) - **Use private/temporary mode** for anything you don't want the assistant to learn, it doesn't read from or write to memory - **At work**, enterprise settings are controlled by your IT team, check what's approved before assuming where your data goes
Deleting a chat removes the conversation, not necessarily what was learned from it. Deleting inferred memory is a separate action.

Additional Resources

Further Learning: - Course 2: *AI-Driven Business Innovation*, Strategic AI investment decisions - Course 3: *AI Leadership & Project Management*, Leading AI project delivery

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Frameworks Reference Sheet

Practical AI for Professionals Masterclass

Your guide to using AI effectively in daily work

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